



gold medal in the 10m mixed team event. Unfortunately, Manu was told that I wanted Chinki in the squad but not the reason for it. That led to a lot of unpleasantness. Manu is a very volatile personality. When she gets an idea stuck in her head, she can be very intense. And it's the same for me," he says.

The rift boiled over at the New Delhi World Cup just a few months before the Olympics, when Chinki beat Manu to a gold in the 25m pistol event. A message would go out to Rana's phone from Manu's, stating "*Shanti mil gayi?* (Are you at peace?)." Unwilling to back down himself, he got the message written on his t-shirt and wore it at the range, where it became the talking point of the fraternity.

Even though Manu was given the chance to compete in three separate events in Tokyo, it was soon very apparent that she seemed out of her depth. She didn't make the Olympic final in either the 10m air pistol or

the 25m pistol events. Paired with Saurabh Chaudhary, she struggled in the mixed team event before going out in the semifinals. Her Olympic campaign was symbolised by an equipment failure in the 10m pistol event and a picture of Indian coach Ronak Pandit putting his arm around her shoulder to console her after yet another missed qualification round.

When she looks back at her Olympic campaign, Manu admits being completely overwhelmed by the experience of competing in Tokyo. "I was just not brave enough. I was just really afraid of everything. I just couldn't focus on myself. I was aware that the Olympics were special, but I had this sense of nervousness that was unlike any other tournament I had competed in previously. I never felt it at the Asian Games, Commonwealth Games, or Youth Olympic Games.

"At the Olympic Games, you see so many established athletes who are already doing so well. Many of

The right guide: It wasn't just his physical presence but also a wealth of technical knowledge that Rana (right) brought to the table for Manu.

RITU RAJ KONWAR

them might have just won a medal. And you see them just hanging around in the Games village and the dining hall, and I just felt I didn't belong among them. I was a kid among all these athletes who were way, way better than me. They might not even have been in the same sport as me. There were basketball players, track and field athletes, and swimmers. I was comparing myself to them. That was very stupid on my part, but it's what I felt at that time," she says.

A maiden Olympics, which should have been a career highlight, now elicits distaste. "Honestly, I have very bitter memories from the Tokyo Olympics. I wondered why this happened to me. What did I do wrong?," she says.

It took her a long time to come to terms with how everything had played out. "I think we all have to make our peace with some situations, especially when it's no longer in our hands. We can't change the past. What happened was unpleasant, but I had to find a way to move on with my life," she says.

Despite what happened both in the run-up and during the Olympics, Manu doesn't see herself as a victim. "It's a tough memory, but it's not traumatic or anything. It's like a difficult set of thoughts that will always be in my head. I cannot flush them out. But when I look back now and see how I was in 2021, I don't think I was mentally ready to compete in an event like the Olympics," she says.

It's the sort of critical self-assessment that's rare in athletes many times her age, let alone someone just out of their teens. "I think it's just that I've grown since what happened in Tokyo. I now look at that experience as a lesson. Starting in 2023, I started to connect the dots of what went wrong and what I could have done so that the